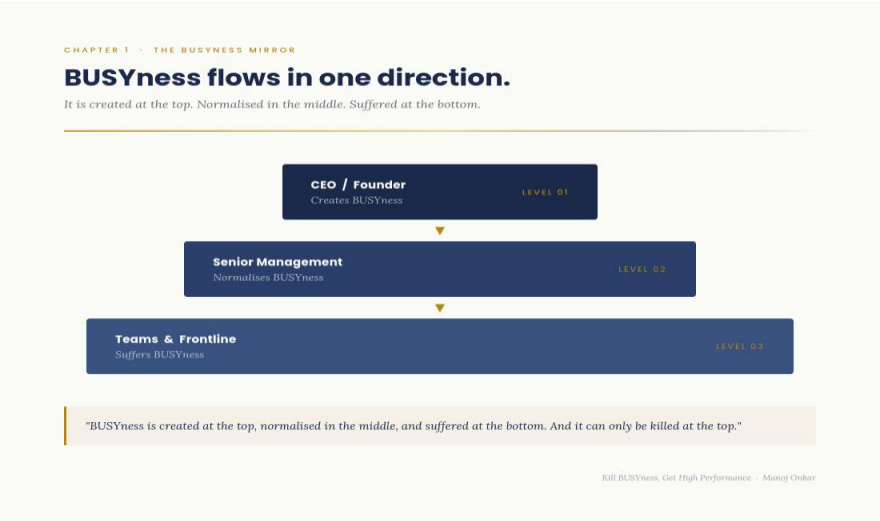

CHAPTER 1

The BUSYness Mirror

"Follow-up is not a management tool. It is a confession."

Are you building a High-Performance Organisation, or a BUSY one?

There is a particular kind of exhaustion that comes not from working hard but from working constantly on the wrong things.

You know the feeling. You end a week having attended twelve meetings, replied to hundreds of messages, resolved three escalations, and somehow, despite all of that frantic activity, you cannot quite name what actually moved forward.

That is not a workload problem. That is a BUSYness problem.

And here is the difficult thing about BUSYness: it feels productive. It has all the hallmarks of urgency, commitment, and effort. Calendars are full. People are responsive. Things are moving. But when you stand back and look squarely at the direction of all that motion — it is circular. The same problems keep resurfacing. The same conversations keep repeating. The same commitments are being chased week after week.

The BUSYness Mirror is the simple act of standing back and looking squarely at your organisation as it actually is — not as it is described in the strategy deck, but as it would appear from the outside — as your clients see it, as your best people experience it, as a thoughtful observer would study it with fresh eyes.

Most leaders avoid this mirror. Not because they don't care, but because BUSYness itself provides such effective cover. When you are moving fast enough, you never have to stop and ask whether you are moving in the right direction.

This chapter asks you to stop.

Consider what that motion actually costs. Research shows CEOs spend up to 72% of their working time in meetings. Upper management: 50%. Middle management: 35%. At every level, the majority of leadership time is consumed not by leading — not by thinking, deciding, or building — but by attending. And yet when those same leaders are asked what actually moved forward last week, the honest answer is rarely found in any of those rooms.

The BUSY Organisation

Let us be specific about what BUSYness actually looks like inside an organisation, because it does not always announce itself as a problem. It usually announces itself as commitment, growth, and hustle.

Meetings are ego trips, not decision engines.

People sit in rooms for hours — updating, presenting, discussing, and deferring. But at the end of two hours, the question "What did we actually decide?" produces a long silence. The meeting felt productive because it was full. But nothing moved.

Research by Atlassian found that 54% of workers leave meetings with no idea what to do next or who owns any action; 71% of senior managers consider the meetings they attend to be unproductive; 63% are conducted without a pre-defined agenda. Harvard Business Review research adds a structural finding: once a meeting has eight or more attendees, its risk of producing nothing meaningful rises sharply. The best-practice benchmark is telling — 80.8% of meetings in high-performing organisations have fewer than eight people in the room. According to Fellow.ai, unproductive meetings cost US businesses upwards of $375 billion every year. Research from Fellow.ai estimates that a single unproductive meeting of eight or more people can cost an organisation upwards of $28,000.

In a BUSY organisation, meetings are where time goes to die dressed as collaboration.

Follow-up is the operating rhythm.

Senior leaders spend eight to twelve hours every week chasing updates, clarifying missed commitments, and extracting basic status. The follow-up message has become such a normal part of the workflow that nobody questions it any more.

According to Asana's State of Work Innovation research, managers now spend 5.8 hours every week in unnecessary meetings alone — an 87% increase since 2019. For individual contributors, unproductive meeting time has risen 118% over the same period. Across the organisation, 53% of working time is now spent on what Asana calls busywork — activity that feels productive but generates no meaningful output. This is not a temporary pressure. It is an accelerating pattern.

In a room of approximately thirty senior leaders from one organisation, we asked a single question: how much of your organisation's time is spent on internal follow-ups? The room was quiet for a moment. Then the answers came: sixty percent. Seventy percent. The number settled around that range. We then asked the second question — what would it be like if you never had to follow up? If every commitment was simply honoured?

The room went quiet again, but differently. People looked at each other. They could not visualise their jobs without follow-up. Not because follow-up was the job. Because follow-up had *become* the job. BUSYness, at sixty to seventy percent.

Standards have been lowered — gradually, almost invisibly.

Not dramatically. Not in a single decision. But slowly, one accommodation at a time, under genuine pressure from real circumstances, the bar has dropped. And the worst part is that most people in the organisation do not even realise the bar has moved. The new lower standard has simply become normal.

People just come to work. Not to fulfil something.

There is a difference, and you can feel it in the first five minutes of a Monday morning. When people are part of something — a real purpose, a meaningful mission, a cause they believe in — they arrive differently. There is an energy that is not manufactured by a motivational poster or a team offsite. When that is absent, people are professionally competent and spiritually hollow. They are doing a job. And they will do it until a better offer arrives.

The same problems keep coming back.

You solve a problem in Q1; it reappears in Q3 wearing a slightly different outfit. You address a team conflict, and it resurfaces three months later with different people in different roles. A BUSY organisation is remarkably efficient at treating symptoms and remarkably poor at ever addressing the underlying conditions that keep producing them.

The BUSYness of Never Growing

One question comes up more than almost any other in our work with CEOs and their leadership teams: why do so many small and mid-size businesses stay exactly that — small and mid-size — for

their entire lives? Not because the market punished them. Not because the opportunity was absent. But because something inside the organisation kept them precisely where they were, generation after generation.

We worked with the leadership team of a fourth-generation family business. The company was 100 years old. By any conventional measure it had survived — a century of markets, recessions, two policy regimes, and competitive shifts that had destroyed many of its contemporaries. But it had never broken through. Still mid-size. Still recognisably the same organisation it had been a generation before.

Beneath the operational issues was something simpler and harder to name: a compromised dream. The organisation had stopped reaching for what it could become. It was managing what it was. BUSYness had filled the space where ambition had once lived — and nobody had noticed it leave.

And then there was the layer particular to family businesses. The senior generation wanted the next generation to own the business and create something new. They said so. They believed it. But when real decisions arrived — on hiring, on pricing, on strategic direction — the control never actually moved. The younger generation's choices were questioned, second-guessed, and quietly reversed. The senior generation did not experience this as control. They experienced it as wisdom. As care. The next generation experienced it as suffocation.

The BUSYness was invisible from the top and entirely visible from below. The organisation was full of motion — meetings, decisions, reviews, activity — but none of it was free. Every significant move required navigation upward before it could go forward. So the real decisions stopped being made. And the organisation remained exactly where it had always been. A hundred-year-old business that still had not decided what it wanted to become.

This is what BUSYness does at its most insidious. It does not just waste time. It replaces ambition.

The High-Performance Organisation

High-Performance is not the absence of pressure. It is the presence of clarity. And there is a profound difference between organisations that operate under pressure and those that have built the internal architecture to perform without requiring constant pressure.

In a High-Performance Organisation, meetings produce decisions.

Jeff Bezos banned PowerPoint presentations from Amazon's leadership meetings entirely, replacing them with six-page narrative memos read in silence at the start of each meeting. No slides. No performing. Every meeting ends with specific decisions and named owners. Bezos described the discipline behind this as "earning the right to take people's time." Meetings required preparation, not just attendance. Outcomes were required, not optional.

Every meeting has a clear purpose, a defined outcome, and leaves the room with specific commitments owned by specific people with specific timelines. There is no "let's take this offline." There is a decision, made, recorded, and owned.

Commitments are honoured without reminders.

This is called NFR — No Follow-Up Required. In an NFR culture, a commitment made is a commitment honoured — not because people are perfect, but because the culture has made keeping commitments the standard and breaking them, without proactive communication, genuinely unacceptable.

Standards are held. Not just set.

The leadership team understands that what they tolerate is what they teach. Every time a standard is compromised without consequence, the organisation learns a little more about what the real standard actually is. High-performance organisations set the standard. Then they hold it — even when it is uncomfortable, even when there is pressure, even when an exception seems harmless.

People come to fulfil something.

Purpose is alive in the daily experience, not just in the annual strategy presentation. People can connect what they are working on today to why it matters. And because of that connection, they bring more. More creativity. More care. More of themselves.

The One Diagnostic Question

Forget the surveys. Forget the engagement scores. There is one question that will tell you, with absolute clarity, which culture you are living in right now.

If the honest answer is yes, you are in a BUSY culture.

Nobody designed this deliberately. Follow-up cultures accumulate — one unfollowed commitment normalised at a time, one missed deadline absorbed without consequence at a time, until chasing became the rhythm, so embedded, so expected, that nobody questions it any more.

The antidote is not more pressure. It is ownership. And ownership begins with the leader.

The BUSYness Index

> *"If you want to know where your organisation really stands — measure it."*

Every organisation has a BUSYness level. Most have never measured it. The BUSYness Index is a simple diagnostic — ten questions, each scored 1–5, that produce a single number revealing how deeply BUSYness has taken hold. It is designed to be completed by the CEO alone first, then collectively by the leadership team.

Score each statement: 1 = Never true, 2 = Rarely true, 3 = Sometimes true, 4 = Often true, 5 = Always true

#	Statement	Score
1	Our meetings end with specific decisions and named owners	
2	Commitments made in this organisation are honoured without follow-up	
3	People in this organisation know exactly why their work matters	
4	Our strategy is visible in the decisions we make every week	
5	Standards are held consistently, even when it is inconvenient	
6	New people receive structured preparation before they are put to work	
7	Cross-functional collaboration is genuine, not politically managed	
8	Leaders at every level develop their people deliberately	
9	The CEO personally models every standard they demand of others	
10	Our culture would sustain itself if the CEO left tomorrow	

Scoring your BUSYness Index:

Total your scores (maximum 50).

Score	BUSYness Level	What this means
43–50	Low BUSYness	High-Performance architecture is operating. Your

Score	BUSYness Level	What this means
		work is to sustain and deepen it.
33–42	Moderate BUSYness	Transition in progress. Address the lowest-scoring items first.
20–32	High BUSYness	BUSY culture is the operating norm. Begin with Chapter 8 — the CEO's personal non-negotiables.
Below 20	Critical BUSYness	Urgent leadership intervention required. Begin today.

The Follow-Up Dependency Score (FDS):

For one week, count every follow-up message you send or receive. Divide by the total number of commitments made that week.

— **FDS below 0.1:** NFR culture operating

— **FDS 0.1–0.4:** Transitioning — identify top 3 sources of dependency

— **FDS above 0.4:** BUSY culture — begin NFR installation immediately (see Chapter 6)

These two numbers — your BUSYness Index and your Follow-Up Dependency Score — are the starting point of every organisational transformation we lead. Write them down. Return to them in 90 days.

BUSYness is Created at the Top

This is the part that most leadership books dance around because it is uncomfortable.

BUSYness is created at the top, normalised in the middle, and suffered at the bottom.

When a CEO operates from a place of reactive urgency — responding to everything, attending every meeting, treating every problem as a crisis — the organisation around them learns that this is what leadership looks like. It learns to generate urgency because urgency gets the leader's attention. It learns to escalate because escalation is rewarded. It learns to confuse activity with progress because the leader, by their own example, has confused the two.

The BUSY leader produces BUSY managers who produce BUSY teams. And everyone is exhausted, and nobody can explain quite why things are not moving faster despite all the effort.

The BUSYness Mirror does not just show you the organisation. It shows you the leader. And sometimes — often — those two reflections are the same.

The difficult question is not "Is my organisation BUSY?" It is "What am I personally doing — in my calendar, my communication, my tolerance, my priorities — that is creating, maintaining, and normalising this BUSYness?"

That question is the beginning.

Sitting with the Mirror

Here is a practice worth adopting right now, before you move to the next chapter.

Sit with your organisation. Not in it. With it. See it as your clients see it. See it as your best employees experience it. See it as a new entrant would study it with fresh, unencumbered eyes.

Ask yourself — not your leadership team, not the deck, not the quarterly review — what is really going on here? Not what the reports say. Not what the official narrative has always been. What is *really* going on?

The answers may be difficult. That is why BUSYness has been hiding them. Discomfort, faced fully and honestly, is not the enemy of High Performance. It is where it starts.

Exercises — Chapter 1: The BUSYness Mirror

The mirror only works if you don't soften what you see. Answer these without softening — not as the leader you wish you were, but as the leader you actually are today.

Exercise 1: The BUSYness Mirror

— If your calendar told the truth about your leadership, what would it say you worship — purpose or activity?

— Where has activity replaced purpose in the last 30 days?

— What does your organisation keep calling urgent that is actually the cost of earlier compromises?

Exercise 2: The Compromise Trail

— List three standards you once held that you no longer hold with consistency. Name them. Do not explain them away.

— Name the difficult conversation or decision you have delayed the longest. How long has it been waiting?

— What have your people learned from what you tolerate? Write it plainly.

Exercise 3: The First Truth

— Write the sentence you least want to write: *"The BUSYness we are living in is being created by..."*

— What one decision will prove, within seven days, that you are choosing High-Performance and not merely admiring it?

The Mirror Question

Count every follow-up message you sent last week and every follow-up you received. Write down the number.

What does that number tell you about your culture?

Do not carry a softened answer into Chapter 2. Carry the truth. The truth is the only useful starting point.

Chapter 2 asks: what is the organisation actually for? Not what it says it is for — what it is demonstrably for, in the decisions that get made every day. That question is the one your BUSYness has been most effectively hiding.